



The Volcano Smokes



Have you ever wondered what is a volcano? And, why do they erupt? Did you know that a volcano is a kind of a mountain that caves down to a pool of molten rock, that sits beneath the Earth's surface?

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Why do some volcanoes smoke at the top? Pressure builds up under the ground due to the magma that forms below. Magma is molten rock mixed with gas. High-pressure forces the gas and rock to shoot up through the opening. Smoking ash clouds are thrown high into the air.

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The magma spills over as lava. Once the lava is erupted, it cools and hardens into rock. Many mountains around the world are volcanoes and have grown or formed in this way.

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The crater is the mouth of the volcano that surrounds the vent and the magma chamber is the underground pool of molten rock found beneath the surface of the Earth.

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A volcano can be active, dormant or extinct. An active volcano has erupted recently and it may erupt again. A dormant one has not erupted in a long time, but, it may still erupt in the future. An extinct volcano erupted thousands of years ago and will probably never erupt again.

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Volcanoes have fascinated people throughout history. What you might not know is that the word 'volcano' comes from the island 'Vulcano', in Italy. It gets its name from the Roman god of fire – Vulcan.

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The myth says that Vulcan lived in a volcano. If the Romans made him angry, he would erupt the volcano and throw lava and ash down upon them.

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